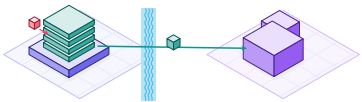
LETHE · SEPTEMBER 2026

Lethe

A privacy harness for the agentic era.



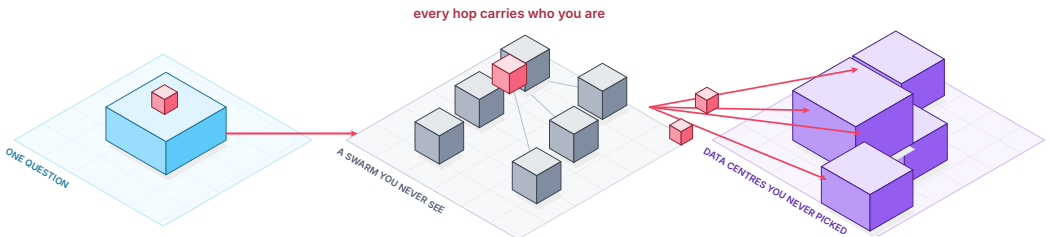
Your agents talk to every frontier model. We make sure none of them learns who you are.

01 · THE SHIFT

You stopped talking to a model.
You started running a swarm.

A planner, a researcher, a booker. Each calls tools, reads the open web, and answers to a different lab. You approved the first message. Nobody approved the other forty.

And all of it carries you.



Your name, employer, family, account numbers, health, the shape of your life. Hundreds of details per session, crossing borders nobody reviewed, into retention windows nobody reads.

The fix on offer is a promise.

- Abuse logs held 30 days. Human reviewers reading raw prompts. Litigation holds that outlive deletion. Five-year retention on opt-in training data.
- Memory features that turn one disclosure into a standing profile of you.
- Every one of those is a policy. Policies change quarterly, and they have.

39.7 %

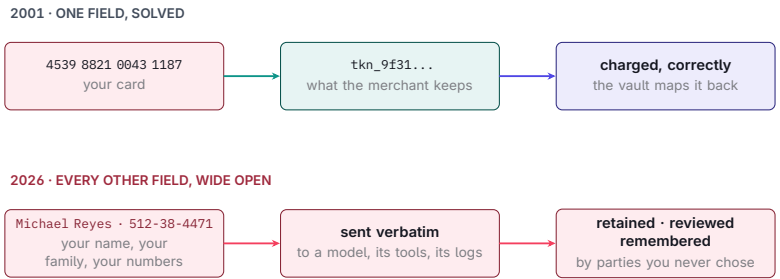
of enterprise AI traffic already carries sensitive data, up from 10.7 % two years ago.

THE PROBLEM, STATED

Today you can only ask a data centre to be trustworthy. You cannot make it incapable of knowing you.

A layer that never emits identity does not depend on anyone's conduct. It survives the next policy change, the next subpoena, and the next breach.

We solved this once, for one field.

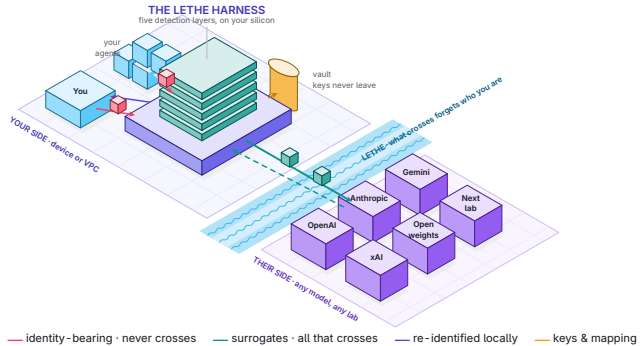


Identity is the field nobody tokenised. Lethe does it, for every model and every agent.

No merchant has held your card number since 2001. They hold a token, and a vault maps it back.

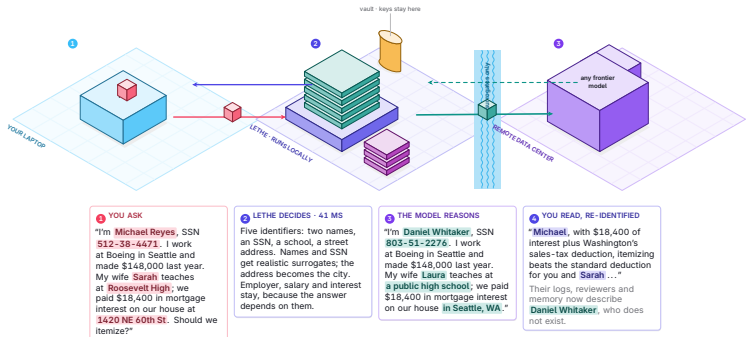
The payment still works. Identity is the field nobody did this for.

Lethe: what crosses forgets who you are.



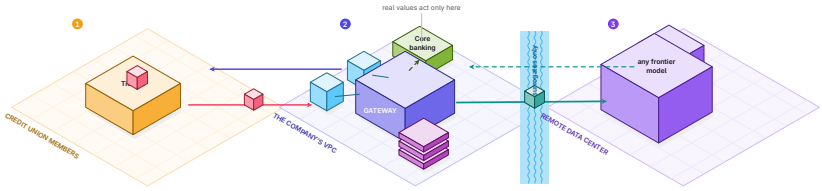
Identity is replaced with realistic surrogates before anything leaves your device or VPC. The keys never leave. The answer is re-identified locally, as it streams. The model gets a convincing double.

One person, one tax question.



Five identifiers are replaced on his laptop. Salary, interest and employer stay, because the answer depends on them. The provider's record describes a person who does not exist.

An AI-native company, one ticket.



Every agent, tool and model speaks to one gateway. Surrogates are consistent across the swarm and different per provider. Real values re-enter only at the action boundary, inside the VPC.

“Doesn’t that make the model dumber?”

It would, if we sent it `[PERSON_1]`. A frontier model is tokenisation, pretraining, then preference optimisation: statistics over token sequences all the way down. It cannot tell whether “Michael Brooks” is a real person. It can absolutely tell that a bracketed tag is not narrative text.

String	GPT-4o	Llama 3.2	Qwen3
`Michael Brooks`	2	2	2
`[PERSON_1]`	5	5	5
`⟨PERSON_3⟩`	9	6	5

tokens per string

- On drafting work, replacing entities costs about one point in ten.
- On 901 real prompts, blunt redaction drops quality 88.2 → 77.2. A tuned pipeline recovers 85.5.
- Realistic, consistent pseudonyms beat tags roughly tenfold. Type-consistent fakes lift BERTScore 81.6 → 94.9.
- The one collapse in the literature came from anonymising a query and its documents *separately*. That is a consistency bug, and it is the thing our architecture exists to prevent.

THE RULE

Tokenise identifiers. Never touch semantics. Amounts, ages and dates stay, because the answer depends on them.

Four things became true this year.

Agents made the blast radius real. A prompt is one hop. A swarm is forty, across tools nobody audited. AWS documents that its own guardrails do not inspect tool-call arguments at all, which is exactly where agent data lives.

Detection became a commodity. A frontier lab open-sourced a local PII model in April. That kills the obvious moat and moves the value to the mapping, the scopes and the proof.

The law moved our way. In September 2025 Europe's high court held that identifiability is judged from the recipient's perspective. Keep the keys on the device and the provider may not be processing personal data at all. Nobody is selling this yet.

Buyers stopped experimenting. Sensitive traffic into AI tools nearly quadrupled in two years, and the security vendors around it are consolidating into platforms. The substrate underneath is still unowned.

THE WINDOW

The detector stopped being the hard part in April. The mapping, the scopes and the proof are now the hard part, and they are the part that compounds.

Everyone owns a piece. Nobody owns the layer.

	Who	What is missing
Detection	Open-source and lab-released PII models	A commodity. Recall collapses on real, multilingual traffic.
Reversible tokens, org-side	Protecto, WitnessAI, Skyflow, Kong	The vendor holds your keys. No agent or MCP path.
Reversible, consumer	Wald.ai; open-source proxies	One session, one user. No swarm, no proof.
Confidential compute	Tinfoil, Confer, Privatemode, Apple	Open-weight models only, and positioned *against* redaction.
Unclaimed	Keys on your side. One consistent identity across a whole swarm. Real values only at the moment of action. A public ledger that proves it.	

WHAT WE ARE NOT

Not another chat wrapper, and not a guardrail bolted onto one vendor's gateway. The privacy substrate that agent builders adopt once and carry to every model.

The ethos.

- **Privacy is an architecture, not a setting.** If a promise can be revoked by a policy update, it was never a guarantee.
- **Nothing to forget, because nothing arrived.** We are not in the business of erasing your data from a model. We are in the business of it never getting there.
- **Claims must be checkable.** Every crossing is signed into a public ledger. If we cannot prove it, we do not say it.
- **Say what is still open.** Quasi-identifiers still leak. Images and voice are not covered yet. We publish that alongside the wins.

> **THE NAME**
>
> *Lethe: the river in Hades whose water erases memory. Mnemosyne: the pool that restores it.* Orphic initiates were told to avoid the first and drink from the second. The model drinks from Lethe. You keep Mnemosyne.

Aletheia, the Greek word for truth, is literally *a-lethe*: un-forgetting. It is what we call the ledger.

Where we start.

Now. A local daemon that any coding agent adopts with one environment variable. The buyer is a developer who already feels this problem and can measure the answer themselves.

Next. The gateway for agent swarms, and a public benchmark: the same real tasks run with and without us, across every major model, judged blind. Published, reproducible, and pointed at ourselves first.

Then. The team deployment, the compliance evidence, and the mark that products carry to say what they never learned about you.

IN ONE LINE

Every AI product will soon have to prove what it never learned about you. We are the layer that makes that proof true, cheap, and portable across every model.

ENGINEERING-HEAVY BY DESIGN

Local-first, no cloud call in the hot path, sub-50 ms added latency, and a tamper-evident log with public checkpoints. The moat is the mapping, the scopes and the proof, never the detector.